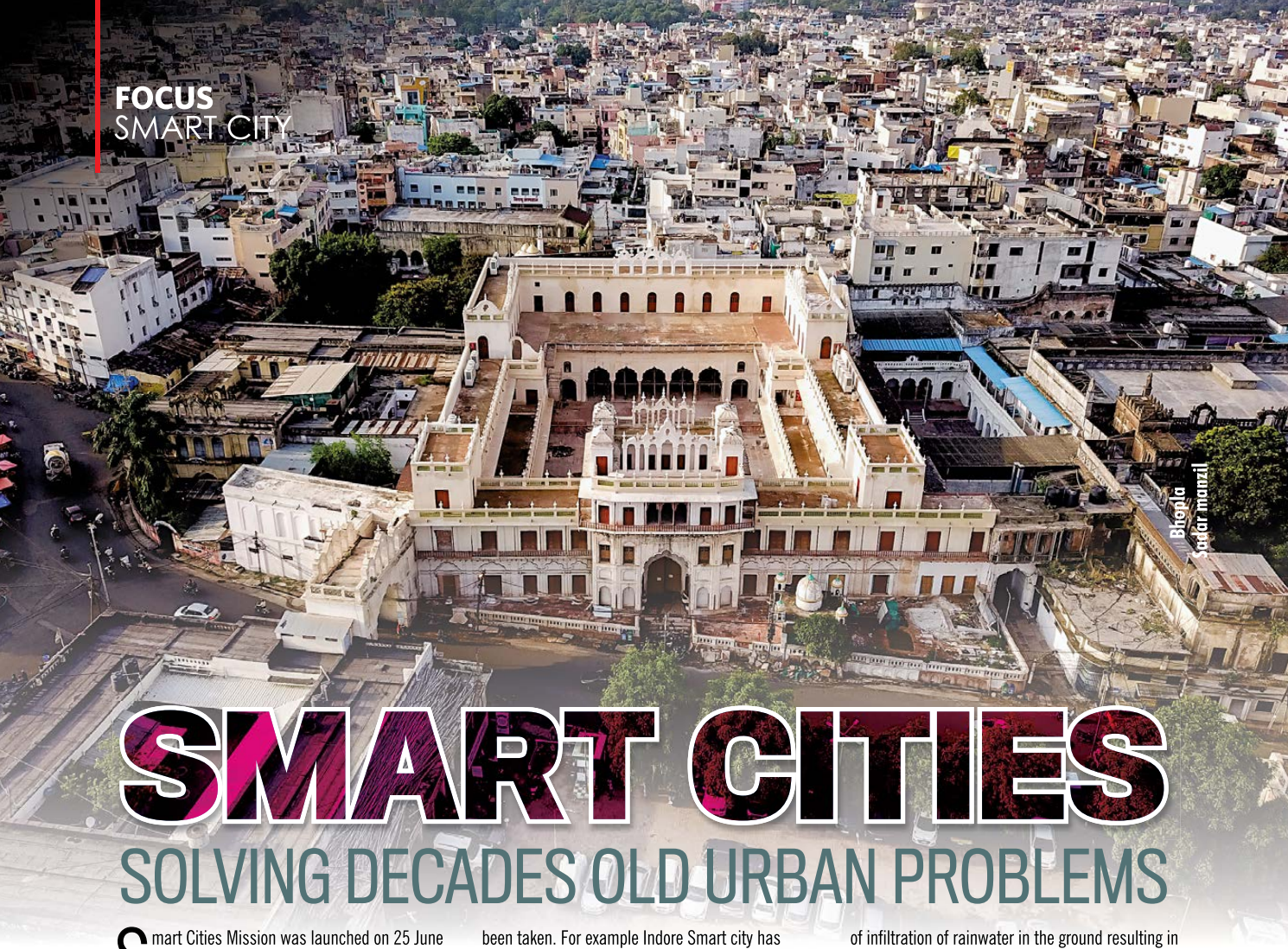

Bhopla Sadar manzil

SMART CITIES

SOLVING DECADES OLD URBAN PROBLEMS

Smart Cities Mission was launched on 25 June 2015. One of key features of this Mission was 'localizing decision making in cities'. The Mission guidelines allowed autonomy to cities to prioritize their programs, projects and initiatives. The Central Government supported each city with Rs. 500 crore each while equal matching share from the State/ local municipality was mandated.

Many of the 100 cities selected under the Mission have utilized this opportunity to solve age-old problems which had been delayed, neglected, or remained insolvable due to several reasons. These problems ranged from neglected public spaces, unsafe Riverfronts/water bodies, poor infrastructure, urban flooding, traffic chaos, slum redevelopment, dilapidated historic monuments etc.

We know that rivers are the backbone of any human civilization! But the condition of our rivers and its edges have been deplorable, and they have been neglected for long. Many cities have utilized the autonomy given under the Mission to initiate notable developments along their river edges. Smart cities are developing public places along their rivers. From Jhelum riverfront in Srinagar, to Sabarmati in Ahmedabad, to Saraswati River in Indore or Tungabhadra River in Shivamogga, from Brahmaputra riverfront in Guwahati to Siang River in Pasighat, or the most revered Maa Ganga in Varanasi. Priority has not been only the riverfront, but a comprehensive development approach including cleaning the river, and making it safe has been taken. For example Indore Smart city has taken up the Saraswati and Kahn River project, preventing 205 MLD sewage outfall into the rivers and thus improved the BOD & COD of the water.

The city of Tumakuru in Karnataka has solved the problems of slum dwellers of the Mariyama Nagar locality. Since past 30 years, the inhabitants had been living in unhygienic conditions. They lacked basic facilities such as water supply, sanitation and electricity. This age-old issue has been resolved by the Tumakuru Smart city by building 88 high-quality dwelling units (3 residential towers to house 87 families), and other social Infrastructure such as anganwadi, a livelihood center and community center space in same complex.

City of Patna has revitalized Adalatganj Lake, one of the oldest but neglected lakes of the city. Neglect arose from transfer of ownerships to different agencies and later changing the purpose of lake from recreational use to leasing it out for fishing. Under SCM, this 2.5 acre lake precinct has been rejuvenated along with public amenities for the people of the city. This project has not only provided citizens access to important public and recreational space but also inspired the city to adopt a similar model of rejuvenation for 50+ other lakes.

City of Davanagere has solved its ages old urban flooding issue causing devastating loss to public and property. Outdated and inadequate physical infrastructure of the city had resulted in reduction of infiltration of rainwater in the ground resulting in higher storm water runoff causing flooding. Under the Smart Cities Mission, the city has created a dedicated 56.71 kms network of storm water drains and sub drains. The integrated drain network is monitored through use of technology. Urban flooding due to heavy rainfalls for the last three decades is history now, from the last three monsoons!

On similar lines, there are other examples. The city of Surat has restored and developed Surat Castle, causing a positive impact on the culture and local economy of the city. It has brought about a sense of pride and identity of the city. City of Agra has solved the sewerage issue in the Tajganj area, a low-lying area not connected to main sewerage line by implementing vacuum-based sewerage system. This project has prevented the discharge of 22,500 liters of sewerage per day into river Yamuna.

Chandigarh has solved its 5 lakh MT legacy waste issue at the Daddu Majra dumping site. Today, the age-old Solid waste hill has ceased to exist. The project has helped reclaim 20 acres of land from waste and resulted in reduction of GHG emissions, soil pollution and Ground water contamination. City of Bhopal has restored the Sadar Manzil heritage precinct, Coimbatore has rejuvenated its 7 city-lakes through holistic planning & development. Kakinada has developed a boat building yard for the community and Shivamogga has developed neglected conservancy lanes into functional ones.